

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Ponmythili Muralidharan

Degrees have become central to how we understand educational progress. Colleges are expanding, enrolments are growing, and more youngsters enter the workforce every year with certificates in hand. By that measure, we should be more educated than we have ever been.

Yet most of us would have met someone whose qualifications gave them real authority, but who used it to intimidate rather than to help. Someone who knew more than the person in front of them and made sure that person felt small for not knowing it.

We recognise this the moment we see it. We rarely stop to ask what it means. It means the qualification arrived, but something else did not.

Distinctions

That something else is education. It is not the same thing as literacy or certification. Literacy gives us access to knowledge. Certification records that we have completed a prescribed course of study. Education is different. It is supposed to change what we do with what we know.

A person may be literate, highly qualified and professionally successful but use knowledge to set themselves apart from others or above them. An educated person uses the same knowledge with greater responsibility, humility



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Education or certification?

Why we need to differentiate between literacy, certification, and education

and awareness of others. This is not a small distinction. It decides what kind of society we are actually building.

I see this shift happen quietly, every year, in my own classroom. I once asked a class to discuss a case without telling them whether it would be assessed. The first question was not about the dilemma in the case. It was, “Ma’am, will this come for the exam?” It was an hon-

est and revealing question. Somewhere along the way, learning had become valuable only when it could be converted into marks.

This is why, over the years, I have tried to create more space for experience alongside assessment. A mark tells you what a student memorised for three hours. It does not tell you what changed in them. When learning is designed to be lived and not just re-

called, students stop asking, “What will be asked?” and start asking, “What does this mean?” That shift captures an important difference between literacy and education within a single classroom.

What is missing

But this is not only a story about individual students or individual professionals who lost their way. It is also a story about a system that has gradually evolved in

ways that often produce this outcome.

Schools and colleges under pressure to place students, to show results, to stay relevant in a competitive market, have increasingly prioritised the job at the end over the person being shaped along the way. Students are prepared to be employable. They are not always prepared to be transformed. That is not a small oversight. It shapes an entire

generation’s relationship with knowledge itself.

The growing interest in experiential and alternative forms of schooling may also reflect this unease. Many parents appear to be looking for learning environments that develop curiosity, independence, and social awareness alongside academic achievement. Whether or not these alternatives offer a complete answer, their appeal tells us something about what families feel is missing from conventional education.

So, perhaps, the more useful question for all of us is not whether our institutions are failing us. It is whether we know what we are actually asking of them. What are we asking for when we choose a school, a college, or a course? Are we asking to be made employable or to be transformed? Once we know the answer, what does that require of us as students, parents, teachers, and educational institutions?

We cannot place the responsibility for this only on the system or the individual. Both have a role in what gets built and both have a role in fixing it. The first step is simply to stop confusing the certificate with the change it was supposed to represent and to start asking, honestly, which one we have actually been given.

The writer is Junior Faculty Organisation - Behaviour and Human Resource at Great Lakes Institute of Management, Chennai.

SCHOLARSHIPS

JK Tyre Shiksha Sarthi Scholarship

An initiative by JK Tyre and Industries Ltd.
Eligibility: Students enrolled in general or professional UG or Diploma courses with 55% in the previous academic year and who are residents of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Karnataka, or Tamil Nadu and are daughters of heavy vehicle drivers and have an annual parental income not exceeding ₹500,000.
Rewards: Up to ₹25,000
Application: Online
Deadline: September 10
www.b4s.in/edge/JKTS4

IDFC FIRST Bank Engineering Scholarship

An initiative by IDFC FIRST Bank.
Eligibility: Students who are Indian citizens in the first year of a B.Tech or B.E. programme (2026-27

academic year) in one of the FIRST IMPACT empanelled colleges and have an annual family income less than or equal to ₹600,000.

Rewards: ₹100,000 a year up to four years.
Application: Online
Deadline: September 20
www.b4s.in/edge/IFBES2

Mahindra EmpowerHer Scholarship

An initiative by Mahindra & Mahindra Limited.
Eligibility: Girl students from the SC, ST or OBC communities in school (Classes 9 to 12) or college (general UG or PG programmes) and have got at least 50% in the previous academic year or semester and have an annual family income should not exceed ₹400,000.
Rewards: ₹5,500
Application: Online
Deadline: September 21
http://www.b4s.in/edge/MNM3

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Yuva Yodha

Schneider Electric has launched Yuva Yodha, a national tech hackathon to create innovative, practical, and scalable solutions for India’s growing energy and sustainability need across four key areas critical to India’s growth and energy transition: Sustainable Agriculture, Smart

Buildings, Grid Reliability and Renewable Intermittency, and Smart Manufacturing
Eligibility: Indian citizens or residents who are full-time students of UG or PG STEM programmes. Participants can compete individually or in teams of up to four members.
Deadline: October 4
Details at yuvayodhatech.com



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

Chart your career

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

Zoology and Robotics. Which has better scope? Which government colleges in India have courses for these? Swara

Dear Swara,
Zoology and Robotics may seem unrelated, but they intersect through emerging fields such as Bio-robotics and Bionics. Robotics offers opportunities in advanced manufacturing, autonomous vehicles, medical robotics, drones and space exploration. It is a fast-growing, high-paying field with global corporate and academic opportunities. Zoology has strong relevance to ecology, conservation and medicine, with careers across wildlife institutes, marine biology labs, genetic research and environmental consulting. An exciting interdisciplinary area is Bio-inspired Robotics, which studies animal movement and mechanics to develop agile, next-generation robots.

To keep options open, choose the Science stream (with Biology and Maths) in Classes 11 and 12. Consider taking the IISER Aptitude Test or CUET and explore integrated B.S.-M.S. programmes at IISc Bengaluru and IISERs. Universities such as BHU, Delhi University and the University of Madras also have established Zoology departments. For Robotics, consider B. Tech programmes in Robotics and Automation or specialisations through Mechanical, Electronics or Mechatronics Engineering. The IITs, IIIT-Allahabad, IIITDM-Kancheepuram and several NITs offer strong options.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

work with an NGO but don’t know how to go about it. Sinthangambi

Dear Sinthangambi,
Working with an NGO can keep you financially independent and provide practical experience for your UPSC interview. Target NGOs focused on education, child rights, and community development such as Social Transformation and Educational Platform (STEP) North-East (Imphal), Korou Education Foundation (Imphal), Seven Sisters Development Assistance (Seesta), and North East Network (NEN). Pan-India NGOs with a strong presence in the northeast are The Hans Foundation and Pratham Education Foundation and Central Square Foundation. Look up portals such as NGOBox.org, DevNet.JobsIndia.org and NGO-Darpan.

Draft a functional resume and highlight your skills. Find the emails of the HR or Project Heads of the NGOs listed above and send emails for roles such as content developer, research associate, or programme coordinator. These are office-based or semi-remote roles where you write reports, design lesson plans, or manage data.

Consider a Fellowship pathway, as it provides a structured stipend and adds value to your resume. The UPSC interview panel values real-world execution over theoretical textbook knowledge. You have a very strong profile. Step into the development sector to secure your financial independence, and use that stability to power your civil services preparation.

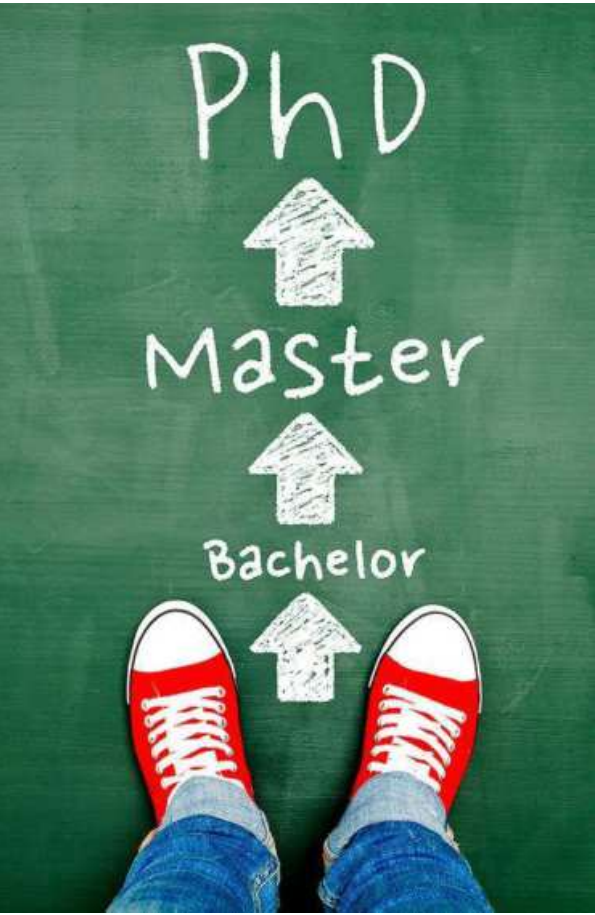
Could you guide us on the

academic pathway to specialise in Dance/Movement Therapy (DMT), which combines my daughter’s interests in Psychology and dance? Prasanth

Dear Prasanth,
To practise as a Dance/Movement Therapist, clinical training with a foundation in Psychology, Anatomy and Neuroscience is required. She will need to do a B.A. or B.Sc. (Hons) Psychology while continuing formal dance training. She can then pursue a Master’s in Counselling or Clinical Psychology and a specialised PG Diploma/Certification in DMT in India. Institutes offering relevant programmes include TISS, Mumbai; Sancheti Healthcare Academy, Pune; and VIMHANS, Delhi, in association with Arts Therapists Co-Lab. Alternatively, she can explore Master’s programmes abroad approved by professional associations such as the American Dance Therapy Association (ADTA) or the U.K.’s Association for Dance Movement Therapy (ADMT). During college, she can intern with or shadow NGOs or special schools that use expressive arts to help her make an informed choice.

DMT and expressive arts therapy are emerging fields with applications in special education, neurodivergence, hospitals, rehabilitation, trauma care and corporate wellness. Abroad, expressive therapists are more integrated into healthcare systems, with opportunities in schools, hospitals, prisons, elder care and rehabilitation centres.

I am in Class 10 and interested in research in



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Equal students, unequal teachers

Why faculty rules in higher education require a rethink

ciplines. While the state’s prerogative to mandate high academic standards such as the Ph.D. is undisputed, its pursuit of excellence must be matched by a corresponding investment in doctoral infrastructure. There are times when a Ph.D. is required but access to it is structurally constrained due to limited supervision capacity or insufficient research vacancies. Then, the requirement risks functioning as an exclusionary barrier rather than a quality benchmark. For instance, in several niche Humanities disciplines such as Tamil epigraphy or regional philosophy, qualified doctoral supervisors are extremely scarce.

A significant hurdle lies

in current Government Orders (GOs), which often stipulate that teaching experience is only counted from the date a faculty member obtains a PhD or qualifies for NET/SET. This policy can result in the abrupt exclusion of seasoned academics who entered the profession prior to acquiring these credentials. There is a strong case for recommending that once a faculty member obtains these qualifications, their entire prior teaching experience be duly recognised.

Furthermore, the academic community would benefit from recognising that pedagogical competencies in the Humanities are fundamentally consistent across institutional

types. Teaching experience gained in Arts and Science colleges should be considered transferable to Engineering institutions. Such a policy would acknowledge the continuity of subject expertise and ensure that veteran educators are not penalised for the specific regulatory environment in which they began their careers.

Towards common ground

The gap between these worlds is beginning to narrow. Recent shifts have seen the AICTE move toward mandating Ph.D.s for senior promotions, while the UGC has made the Ph.D. optional at the entry-level for those who have cleared the NET or SET. To build on these corrections, the system could benefit from further nuanced reforms:

Graduated entry: Implementing provisional appointments for lecturers who commit to completing a doctorate within a specific timeframe.

Qualitative assessment: Integrating more analytical components into national eligibility tests.

Experience recognition: Validating full career longevity and allowing experience transferability between Arts and Engineering streams for Humanities faculty members to preserve institutional memory.

Ultimately, the classroom remains oblivious to the specific regulatory body governing the teacher. By reconciling regulatory rigour with structural accessibility and recognising the full value of a teacher’s tenure, India can protect its intellectual future and ensure its scholars continue to flourish.

Views expressed are personal and do not represent the views, policies, or positions of the institution the author works in.

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